

STATISTICS BEYOND THE METRICS

NOVEMBER 10, 2025

Statistics does not always exist in its own department - groups are found within Mathematics, Computer Science, Data Science, Econometrics, and Business Analytics departments. However, within the Big Ten, there are fourteen Departments of Statistics and one School of Statistics (Minnesota). Two additional schools (USC, Maryland) have a group of statisticians within the math department. University of Oregon, the longtime exception, has recently created a School of Computer and Data Science and is actively hiring statisticians to support this initiative.

Many AAU schools have both Statistics and Biostatistics groups on campus. Of 40 public AAU universities, only two do not have Statistics groups on campus (Univ. Utah, Univ. Oregon), and both of these have separate Data Science units. Only 9 of the 40 public AAU universities do not have Biostatistics departments in addition to their statistics groups.

By eliminating the Department of Statistics at UNL, we will be exceptions within the Big Ten and the AAU.

Many scientists, national academy members, and administrators from prestigious universities around the world wrote in during the APC process to provide letters of support.

Common themes:

- Statistical expertise is critical for obtaining external competitive funding.
- Stat depts are lean, generating profits from service courses w/o equipment & lab overhead.
- Most universities are hiring statisticians and growing statistics programs to meet demand.
- UNL's BS degree is competitive & well designed. Eliminating the program before it graduates its first class is premature.
- Eliminating Statistics will do long-term damage to the university's reputation across disciplines.
- Closing the department will be seen as a failure of institutional vision.

The Statistics department is not well represented by the metrics used to assess departments.

Teaching

- New undergraduate major in 2022, first class (7 students) graduates Fall 2025/Spring 2026.
- Undergraduates count as majors but cannot yet earn degrees, decreasing the Degrees/Majors ratio
- New program, new courses, small cohorts – temporary decrease in SCH and SCH/FTE. New courses are already seeing increased enrollment - Stat 251 is at capacity for Spring 2025.
- New courses taken by students in Statistics (est. 2022), Data Science (est. 2022), Digital Ag Minor (est. 2023) – all new programs!

Cutting Statistics before these new programs have time to mature will prevent the inevitable return on these investments - a “buy high, sell low” strategy. These new programs represent an *investment* that is just *beginning to pay dividends*.

Research

- Higher turnover due to industry competition
- Research metric includes only 34% of possible faculty person-years.
- ~25% of current faculty not included in metrics.
- SRI for Statistics is 0.4 – just below median SRI for public AAU statistics departments
- Department size is very small compared to peers – but we offer programs at all levels (BS, MS, PhD) and have respectable research output.
- Statistics is critical for AAU goals and competitive grants **across disciplines**

The size of the public AAU SRI - public SRI shift (Figure 3) indicates the relative change in the discipline's rating in public AAU (dotted line) vs. public non-AAU (solid line) schools. Fundamental disciplines (Stat, Chem, Physics, Math) have large shifts, indicating their importance to the ecosystem of a public AAU university.

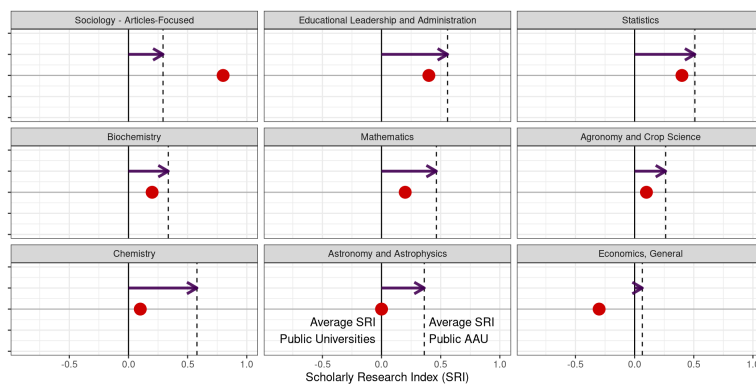


Figure 3. SRI shift for selected disciplines.

Conclusion

Statistics is a **mission-critical** department for a land-grant R1 university with AAU aspirations. Eliminating the department will damage the reputation of the University of Nebraska on the national and international stage and limit competitiveness for national grants across the university. New programs are just beginning to grow and will be highly profitable based on experience at peer institutions.

See more information (presentations, APC report) at saveourstats.com

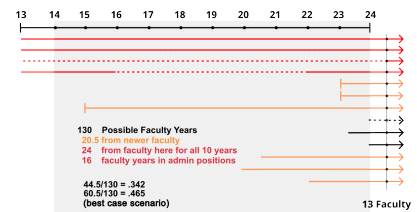


Figure 1. New hires (orange), Admin appts (dotted), 2024 hires (black), veteran faculty (red). Degrees indicated with |—.

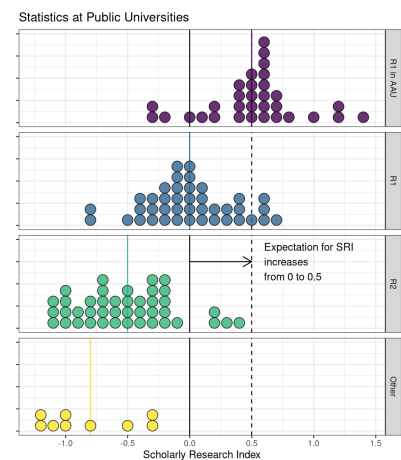


Figure 2. Statistics SRI increases with University status.